Method planning grid

63

AP RESEARCH · PLAN BEFORE YOU WRITE THE METHOD SECTION

STUDENT CODE _____ PERIOD _____ DATE _____

Copy your question from your log, word for word. Then plan each method in its own column. One method is fine: leave the second column empty.

_____

_____

	Method 1: _____	Method 2 (if you use one): _____
Why? Why this method fits your question. Why this and not another method.		
What? The instrument and how long it takes one person.		
When? Dates, and how many times.		
Who? Who you gather data from, how many, how you reach them.		
After gathering data How you will analyze it and what you will compare.		

Approval I need before I start

_____

Methods text I will cite to justify this

_____

What a filled-in grid looks like

63

EXAMPLE ONLY · DO NOT COPY

The topic here is invented to show the level of detail: *how students use the library's quiet study room*. Your grid comes from your own question.

	Method 1: Short questionnaire	Method 2: One-to-one interviews
Why? Why this method fits your question. Why this and not another method.	*To get counts: how often people use the room and at what times.*	*To learn the reasons behind the counts. Interviews, not a focus group, because schedules are personal and people speak more freely alone.*
What? The instrument and how long it takes one person.	*12 questions on paper. About 5 minutes.*	*6 open questions. About 15 minutes. Notes by hand, no recording.*
When? Dates, and how many times.	*One week, once per person, after approval is logged.*	*The week after the questionnaires come back.*
Who? Who you gather data from, how many, how you reach them.	*Students who use the room. Guardian permission and student assent first. Aim: every user that week.*	*Volunteers from the questionnaire group. Aim: 5 or 6.*
After gathering data How you will analyze it and what you will compare.	*Tally each answer. Compare by grade level. Report every count with its total.*	*Code the notes for repeated reasons. Report each theme with how many people raised it.*

What to notice. Every "why" names a reason, and one rejects an alternative. The second method explains the first: the interviews give reasons for the counts. The "who" for Method 2 comes out of Method 1. Each "after" says what will be compared and how it will be reported.

If two methods do not connect, you have two small studies. Ask: what does Method 2 tell me that Method 1 cannot?

Check your own grid

- Could a classmate run my study from this page alone?
- Does each "why" give a reason, not a description?
- Is the time I ask of each person stated?
- Do I know what approval I need, and have I allowed time for it?
- Can I name what my data will **not** be able to show?